Advertising research for audience benefit and sustainable distribution

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Executive overview

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Advertising is most defensible when it helps people make a better voluntary decision and creates additional useful outcomes at an acceptable full cost. The objective is not maximum exposure, clicks, persuasion, time spent, or revenue in isolation. A suitable person discovering a useful tool can be a success. So can someone understanding the limitations and deciding not to use it. Neither a click nor a refusal proves benefit by itself.

For Blackwish, the strongest candidate direction is a truthful, accessible demonstration of an actually available build, supported by a complete explanation and a reusable sample. The communication should help a newcomer understand what the project does, what the person contributes, what is free, what works offline, and what remains limited. This is a reasoned candidate strategy, not a validated advertising recipe or a finding that Blackwish is ready for public release.

Five conclusions organize the research:

- **Measure additional useful outcomes.** Advertising often receives credit for behavior that would have happened anyway. It can also cause outcomes without a tracked click. Attribution and causal effect are different quantities.
- **Make creativity serve understanding.** Originality, entertainment and memorability can be valuable, but do not automatically improve decisions, learning, purchases or welfare.
- **Separate three economic purposes.** Buying discovery for a free tool, acquiring paying customers, and hosting ads to fund a product require different models. Free downloads do not establish revenue or lifetime value.
- **Treat trust and agency as constraints.** Truthful claims, clear commercial relationships, accessibility, privacy and protection of children are not optional deductions from a profitable result.
- **Keep Blackwish claims within demonstrated scope.** Internal preview checks are not independent public-release validation, mobile verification, proof of learning, or certification of universal safety.

This dossier combines primary research, official guidance and explicit design inference. It is a focused research synthesis, not a preregistered systematic review. No campaigns, budgets, outreach, human experiments, tracking installations, publication, ratification or deployed revisions were carried out. The worked numbers are invented teaching examples, not Blackwish forecasts. Publication, spending, live data collection or audience experiments, and deployment remain subject to applicable explicit authorization and manual ratification.

What benefit should mean

Advertising performs several jobs: announcing existence, explaining capabilities and price, helping people assess fit, reminding them of a relevant option, financing media or services, and supporting a creator's continued work. These jobs can align, but need not. A profitable promotion can still waste audience time; an informative message can benefit someone who never buys.

The following ledger is an organizing proposal, not a validated score. Keep the dimensions visible rather than converting every human cost into an invented dollar amount.

Beneficiary	A worthwhile outcome	A misleading substitute
Audience	Correct understanding, useful discovery, a completed chosen task, enjoyable standalone material, informed refusal	Clicks, exposure, purchase intention, or time spent treated as proof of benefit
Creator	Sustainable net contribution, accurately matched demand, fewer avoidable misunderstandings	Gross revenue, attributed conversions, or audience size without costs
Publisher or free service	Funding that preserves a usable, trustworthy experience	More impressions or subscriptions produced by making the free experience worse
Wider public	Honest information, accessible participation, privacy and credible commercial boundaries	Aggregate profit assumed to compensate for deception or unequal burdens

An informative ad can improve matching rather than simply increase demand. In a preregistered simulated-bookstore experiment, price and genre information changed advertised-book demand and search choices in different ways. Some people rejected a book without further search; total search did not change. The finding supports inspecting information and fit, not assuming every refusal saves effort or every extra search helps. [14]

Welfare evidence is mixed and setting-specific. A published Facebook study compared users in a long-term no-feed-ads holdout with ads users through incentivized deactivation valuations. Among 53,083 participants, it found no significant valuation difference; small net disutility or offsetting discovery benefits were possible explanations. This does not establish that all advertising is harmless, or measure every purchase, privacy externality or vulnerable subgroup. [16]

By contrast, a 21-month Pandora experiment involving almost 35 million listeners found that higher ad load reduced listening; long-run sensitivity was about three times a one-month estimate. Higher load also increased ad-free subscriptions. Subscription uptake can therefore coexist with a worse free experience. This is evidence about in-product ad load, not a campaign-frequency prescription for Blackwish. [15]

A practical rule: require a plausible audience benefit and a sustainable resource model, while maintaining protective constraints. Do not let a profitable conversion automatically cancel deception, unwanted data collection or an audience loss. Also do not reject a mission-funded

activity merely because it is not commercially profitable; describe it honestly as a subsidy with an accountable purpose and funding limit.

What the causal evidence establishes

Evidence types and transfer limits

Randomized field evidence can identify an intervention's effect within its design, population and horizon. **Controlled laboratory or simulated-choice evidence** can test mechanisms but may not reproduce real-market consequences. **Observational or model-based evidence** depends on identification and measurement assumptions. **Official guidance and standards** explain obligations or recommended practice; they do not prove advertising efficacy. **Candidate applications** in this dossier are reasoned proposals, not measured Blackwish effects.

Many studies measure purchases, visits, recall or stated intentions rather than long-term welfare. Large samples do not eliminate selection bias, a platform relationship does not automatically invalidate a study, and peer review does not establish universal transportability. Several sources were verified through original abstracts or author manuscripts; unsupported missing statistics are not filled in.

Evidence matrix

Evidence	Design and central result	What it does not establish
Gordon and colleagues 2019 [1]	Fifteen US Facebook experiments benchmarked observational methods across 500 million user-experiment observations and 1.6 billion impressions. Rich controls often failed to recover experimental effects.	The observations are not 500 million unique people. There is no universal dashboard correction factor.
Gordon and colleagues 2023 [2]	Benchmark of 663 Facebook experiments with over 5,000 user features. Median randomized lower-funnel lift was 5%, versus 24% for one double/debiased machine-learning approach.	These are relative-lift medians, not percentage-point changes or a Blackwish forecast. More features do not guarantee causal identification.
Blake and colleagues 2015 [3]	eBay search experiments found no measurable short-term branded-search benefit. New and infrequent users responded better to nonbrand search than frequent users.	Not proof that search is useless for unknown products, contested queries, all users or all horizons. No measurable effect is not exact zero.
Simonov and colleagues 2018 [4]	Bing work showed substantial paid-organic substitution and a role for competitive search placement. In the unopposed cost analysis, 36.4 paid clicks accompanied 2.27 additional clicks per 100 searches.	Clicks are not incremental profit. Defended and undefended brands were partly self-selecting; competitive-diversion figures are not universal causal sales effects.

Evidence	Design and central result	What it does not establish
Lewis and Reiley 2014 [5]	Randomized retail study of 1.6 million matched customers found about 5% higher purchases. Of the estimated incremental increase, 93% was offline and 78% came from nonclickers.	These are shares of incremental lift, not all sales. A 2007 retail campaign is not a modern software benchmark.
Johnson and colleagues 2017 [6]	Ghost-ad retargeting study recorded counterfactual ad opportunities; the application found 17.2% relative visit lift and 10.5% purchase lift.	Not every retargeting campaign is incremental. This approach needs suitable infrastructure and a valid control design.
Dai and colleagues 2023 [7]	Yelp experiment with 18,294 restaurants, including 7,209 randomly offered three months of free ads, increased purchase-intention outcomes by 7-19% and reviews by 5%.	Intentions and reviews are not sales or profit. A free package's effect does not prove its market-price economics.
Shapiro and colleagues 2021 [8]	Model-based TV analysis of 288 established consumer-goods brands found small median elasticity and substantial ROI uncertainty, with important margin and carryover assumptions.	Not randomized proof that most advertising is waste. Total-schedule value and the value of additional spending are different.
Lewis and Rao 2015 [9]	Twenty-five field experiments covering $2.8 million of advertising had a median ROI confidence-interval width exceeding 100 percentage points.	Inconclusive experiments do not prove no effect; apparently precise observational estimates may still be biased.
Sethuraman and colleagues 2011 [10]	Meta-analysis of 56 historical studies reported mean short- and long-term sales elasticities of 0.12 and 0.24.	Elasticity is not ROAS. Heterogeneous historical estimates do not justify doubling a campaign's short-run return.
Simester and colleagues 2009 [11]	Controlled direct-mail work found future effects could differ by customer group; short-term purchases could substitute across time or ordering channels.	An immediate increase need not represent durable additional demand. Catalog-retail dynamics need not transfer to a free creative tool.

The evidence rejects two easy stories. Advertising is not always worthless: some interventions cause additional purchases. It is not automatically valuable either: some spending mainly captures credit for existing demand. The decision must concern the particular alternative, useful outcome, full cost and uncertainty.

Prediction versus intervention: a person likely to buy may be unlikely to change behavior because of an ad. Targeting the most likely purchaser can produce an impressive dashboard without much incremental benefit. Conversely, judging only tracked clickers can miss real effects. This is why strong prediction, high conversion rates and good causal evidence should not be treated as interchangeable. [1] [5]

Measuring benefit without confusing the quantities

Define the counterfactual

Ask what the same eligible population would have done under a specified alternative: no campaign, a lower budget, a different channel, or another delivery policy. Those are different questions. A comparison of creative A with B does not show whether either beats no advertising. A campaign effect at one budget does not identify the effect of doubling spend. A channel holdout with other channels running estimates a conditional contribution; channel effects may interact rather than add neatly.

A future authorized design would distinguish assignment from actual delivery, and delivery from clicking. Platform algorithms can make different creatives reach different subsets. A review of 133 online-platform studies highlighted such causal-overclaiming risks. A correctly analyzed randomized intention-to-treat comparison across all assigned users can still estimate the combined creative-and-delivery policy; it does not isolate the wording's psychological effect among delivered impressions. [12]

For any future empirical work, the design specification would need assignment unit, eligibility, primary outcome, minimum worthwhile effect, horizon, exclusions, interference, missing outcomes, decision threshold and stopping rule. Repeatedly checking results until one looks significant, or selecting a winner from thousands of unreported variants, creates additional uncertainty. These are planning requirements only; this report does not initiate testing or data collection.

Keep the outcome ladder separate

Stage	Useful question	Common error
Delivery	Was a valid placement delivered and measurable?	Treating a billed opportunity as a human impression
Viewability and attention	Could it be seen, and was attention measured credibly?	Treating viewability or attention as persuasion
Understanding	Did the person understand the actual proposition and limits?	Treating recall of a slogan as accurate understanding
Voluntary action	Did the person choose an appropriate next step?	Treating every click or refusal as inherently beneficial
Useful outcome	Did the person accomplish a task they valued?	Counting unsuccessful attempts as successes
Incrementality	Did the activity cause additional useful outcomes?	Crediting all observed activity to the campaign
Sustainability	Were full costs, funding and burden acceptable?	Using gross receipts or engagement as net value

For Blackwish, the proposed primary outcome is **incremental successful voluntary useful outcomes**. A completed one-time character and usable export can be full success. Retention is relevant only when the person's need recurs. More time can mean enjoyment or confusion; fewer support requests can mean clarity or abandonment. Usage is not evidence of learning transfer.

Arithmetic example of attribution and causality

All quantities below are invented for explanation, not measured Blackwish data, a proposed experiment, or evidence of statistical significance.

Imagine two comparable policy groups of 10,000 people. Without a campaign, 200 complete a useful creation; with it, 240 do. A hypothetical $400 campaign receives dashboard credit for 160 conversions.

Quantity	Calculation	Meaning
Absolute lift	2.4% minus 2.0% = 0.4 percentage points	Difference in outcome rates
Relative lift	0.4% divided by 2.0% = 20%	Increase relative to baseline
Additional successes	10,000 times 0.004 = 40	Extra successes in the campaign-sized population
Attributed cost	$400 divided by 160 = $2.50	Cost per dashboard-credited conversion
Incremental cost	$400 divided by 40 = $10	Media cost per additional success

The $10 omits creative, measurement, serving and support. It also suppresses sampling uncertainty for this arithmetic illustration. If recurrence matters, estimate the incremental recurring-use outcome separately; do not multiply overall retention by first-use lift without justified assumptions. Do not penalize a person whose one-time need is satisfied.

Models and uncertainty

Marketing-mix models can use aggregate data, saturation and carryover without much individual tracking. Their causal interpretation still relies on assumptions about confounding, variation, lag structure and functional form. Predictive fit alone is not causal validation. A small project cannot create identifying information by fitting a more elaborate model to sparse data. [13]

Report absolute and relative effects, denominators, interval estimates, observation horizon and the economic threshold. Distinguish evidence of worthwhile benefit, evidence excluding a worthwhile benefit, and insufficient information. A result compatible with both material benefit and material loss remains uncertain; a positive point estimate is not a profitability certificate. Explicit assumptions and a conservative decision can be more useful than a spurious precise forecast.

Creative that helps rather than merely attracts

Originality and relevance

Research on perceived advertising creativity distinguishes divergence from relevance. Another study comparing creative commercials with controls found improved unaided recall but not purchase intention or brand attitude. Thus originality can help a message register without proving that it helps the audience decide or the creator earn. [17] [18]

For Blackwish, let a surprising character choice explain an actual creative decision. A viewer should still understand the offering if the decorative spectacle is removed. A beautiful story trailer can be enjoyable yet imply a finished animated series rather than the actual tool. A joke requiring insider lore can delight existing fans while excluding a newcomer. Neither is inherently forbidden; the product explanation must remain accurate.

Clarity and representative experience

Plain-language research in legal texts found avoidable linguistic complexity impaired comprehension and recall. That is adjacent evidence, not an advertising-conversion estimate. The practical inference is to remove unnecessary difficulty while preserving material qualifications. Short copy that hides price, setup, rights or platform limits is not clear merely because it is brief. [19]

Product-trial research found trial-based attitudes better predicted later purchase in its setting. Free-sample field experiments separately identified expansion, acceleration and displacement of paid trial, with substantial brand differences. These support considering representative experience, not a claim that free samples always create paying demand or that a permanently free core is financially sustainable. [20] [21]

A candidate demonstration should show one complete supported sequence: the person's intention, the relevant controls, the actual result, and a usable export if supported in the tested build. Identify selection, editing, acceleration, human illustration and simulated interactions. Keep a deeper walkthrough optional rather than withholding the essential answer until signup.

Entertainment and teaching

Interesting irrelevant details reduced recall or transfer in classic science-learning experiments, but a later carefully matched study did not find a consistent detriment. The balanced lesson is to inspect whether decoration competes with the intended explanation, not to prohibit beauty, characters or jokes. These are learning studies, not validation of Blackwish instruction. [22] [23]

Humor studies illustrate competing outcomes: preventive-health ads gained message recognition and convincingness in one program, while another found impaired conscious memory for product names. Narrative transportation research also found reduced noticing of false notes in one study. Enjoyment is a legitimate benefit; reduced scrutiny should not be the persuasion objective. [24] [25] [26]

A complete G-rated vignette can be valuable even when the viewer never downloads anything. Separate fictional capabilities from factual product claims. A comic character saying that a tool makes everyone creative still communicates a claim needing support. Educational material should identify the skill actually explained; usage or enthusiasm does not demonstrate durable learning.

Repetition and free offers

Experiments found unfamiliar brands could wear out earlier under repeated advertising. Separate research found repetition can increase perceived truth even when relevant knowledge is available. Neither supplies a universal exposure optimum. Repetition should support requested recall or add useful information, not grind down resistance or make an unsupported slogan familiar. [27] [28]

Experimental zero-price research found shifts in choice toward free options; it did not establish greater educational or practical value. State precisely what is free and what conditions remain. Free of charge, open source, modifiable, commercially usable and public domain are different propositions. A free core can be the complete useful offering, not merely an incomplete funnel. [34]

Accessibility in the creative itself

Provide accurate captions for meaningful speech and non-speech sound, and a descriptive transcript where essential actions are visual. Uncorrected automatic captions may be inadequate. Pause, stop or hide requirements for moving content have specific conditions; a five-second threshold is not permission to distract or flash. [29] [30] [31]

Useful candidates include readable labels, meaningful still images, playback controls, explanations not dependent on color alone, and a text or printable equivalent. A QR-only poster or an online-only explanation can frustrate offline access. These practices improve inspectability; they do not establish that the product or campaign conforms to an accessibility standard.

Choosing distribution by the job it must do

Owned material is creator-controlled, such as documentation. **Organic** refers to unpaid discovery, whether of owned or third-party material. **Earned** discussion is independent coverage or recommendation. **Paid** distribution includes purchased placement and compensated promotional relationships. A tutorial can be promotional without paid placement; a paid endorsement does not become earned praise because it appears on a personal account.

A structural study of a new television show modeled different mechanisms and exposure levels for paid and earned media. Its results do not establish a universal channel ranking. Similarly, field evidence on contextual matching and obtrusiveness found a worse combination than either alone for purchase intention; this does not endorse interruption or establish contextual advertising as a universal economic winner. [33] [32]

The table below is a design comparison, not measured Blackwish performance or a spending recommendation.

Format or channel	Candidate useful role	Principal boundary
Complete project page and documentation	Explain features, limits, rights and supported steps in one updateable reference	Requires discovery and maintenance; owned does not mean impartial
Captioned video demonstration	Show sequence, human contribution and actual result	Editing can overstate ease; bandwidth and access matter
Print activity or downloadable guide	Provide a usable example without continuous connectivity	Printing, distribution, readability and maintenance have costs
Poster or outdoor announcement	Make existence or a public activity discoverable	Poor place for complex qualifications; avoid QR-only access
Audio or radio	Explain purpose or offer a clearly fictional sample without a screen	Cannot alone demonstrate visual controls; needs a text counterpart
Voluntary workshop or demonstration	Answer questions and reveal real limitations	Capacity, access and social pressure; attendance is not research consent
Relevant nonbrand search	Reach someone actively seeking the supported task	Existing intent does not prove incremental value
Branded search	Navigation or protection of a contested result	May mostly replace organic arrival
Contextual placement or transparent sponsorship	Reach a relevant setting with an intelligible commercial relationship	Contextual labels do not guarantee minimal data collection or good economics
Retargeting	A possible reminder of unfinished useful work	Natural return, stale intent, excess repetition and privacy burden
Independent recommendation	Add another person's experience or criticism	Cannot honestly guarantee reach, positivity or editorial control

A reasonable candidate sequence is to make the reference explanation and genuine sample worthwhile first, then ask what distribution adds. This is not a claim that unpaid reach will suffice. It prevents paying to amplify confusion. The marginal alternative may be better onboarding, translation, reliability or documentation rather than another impression.

Economics for a free creative project

Three models that must not be blended

Mission distribution spends resources to create additional useful outcomes. Without a supported revenue mechanism, it is a distribution expense, not financial customer acquisition. A subsidy can be worthwhile without being profitable, but needs a purpose, funding source and affordable-loss limit.

Financial acquisition seeks incremental net receipts from a defined legitimate offering. Donation, patronage, licensing and optional purchases are not assumed simply because users exist. Forecasts require actual payment, refund, service and retention evidence, with consistent cohorts and horizons.

Publisher funding sells advertising or sponsorship to fund free access. It introduces screening, interruption, privacy, operational and reputational costs. Buying ads for Blackwish and placing ads inside Blackwish are separate decisions; neither follows automatically from the other.

Accounting identities

Let acquisition cost A include media, attributable production, labor, measurement and setup, without double-counting. Let additional useful outcomes be Q, additional receipts be R, and additional non-acquisition variable costs be V, all relative to a credible alternative and over a stated horizon.

- Cost per additional useful outcome = A divided by Q, when Q is positive and meaningfully identified.
- Incremental operating contribution after acquisition = R minus V minus A.
- With constant contribution-margin fraction m, contribution before acquisition = m times incremental revenue.
- Payback is the first period when cumulative incremental cash contribution covers acquisition cash outlay; it may never occur.
- Contribution-margin lifetime value is an explicitly modeled discounted net stream for a defined cohort, not a dollar label attached to every free download.

These are accounting explanations, not financial projections or a recommended Blackwish budget. Margin definitions, discounts, tax, shared costs and capacity constraints must be handled consistently in any real decision.

Worked mission and commercial examples

Invented assumption or result	Mission distribution example	Optional commercial example
Media	$1,000	$1,000
Creative and measurement	$300 plus $100	$300 plus $100
Total acquisition cost	$1,400	$1,400
Incremental useful outcomes	50	Not inferred from revenue alone
Incremental financial return before acquisition	No receipts; $100 serving cost	$3,000 revenue at 40% contribution margin = $1,200
Net financial effect	$1,500 mission spending	$200 loss
Honest interpretation	$30 total spending per additional useful outcome	Media-only revenue ratio is 3 to 1, yet contribution is negative

The examples are intentionally simple. They do not establish that 50 additional outcomes can be identified precisely, that the audience benefited, or that the activity is affordable. A comparison should also consider what the same resources could accomplish without advertising.

Worked publisher example

Suppose there are 100,000 ad opportunities, 60% are filled, and realized net eCPM is $4 per thousand counted paid impressions. Revenue is 100,000 times 0.60 times $4 divided by 1,000 = **$240**, before incremental infrastructure, review, privacy and operating costs. Every number is invented, not a market benchmark. Match the eCPM denominator to the impression count; do not apply fill or viewability twice.

Even positive net receipts would not settle the audience decision. Advertising could slow creation, interrupt attention, expose unsuitable destinations or erode trust. Conversely, appropriate sponsorship might fund useful material with little interruption. Those are competing candidate mechanisms, not demonstrated Blackwish outcomes.

Cash and capacity

A positive long-run estimate can still exhaust cash before payback. Use explicit pessimistic, base and optimistic cases; show value beyond observed data separately. Do not count hypothetical investment or donations as available cash. Allow for support, moderation, updates, storage, accessibility and maintenance. If increased traffic exceeds the capacity to deliver the promised experience, acquisition can worsen the very outcome being promoted.

The relevant spending question is marginal: what does the next increment add, compared with its best alternative? A profitable small campaign need not remain profitable when scaled into more expensive auctions or less responsive audiences. No generic percentage of revenue or universal LTV-to-CAC ratio resolves these questions.

Delivery quality privacy and public trust

An impression is not a benefit

MRC desktop viewability guidance generally uses at least half the pixels in view for one continuous second for display and two for video, with exceptions and format-specific requirements. That is an opportunity to see, not evidence of looking, remembering or benefiting. [35]

The final November 2025 IAB/MRC attention guidelines explicitly reject attention as a standalone effectiveness measure and recognize nonlinear or negative relationships with outcomes. They do not require demographic identity assignment. Attention maximization is therefore not justified even by the industry's own attention-measurement framework. [36]

ANA's Q1 2026 participating-sample benchmark reported 43.3% of programmatic investment meeting a composite of fraud-free, measurable, viewable and made-for-advertising-free criteria. This is a trade-association delivery-quality benchmark, not a census, a causal management study, or proof that the remainder produced no sales. The login-gated Q2 full report was not used. [37]

Procurement questions for any later proposal

Specify what is billed; where placements can appear; treatment of bots, duplicates, accidental clicks and discrepancies; fee and rebate incentives; cancellation and refund routes; and what reporting can be independently interpreted. A cheap CPM may buy unsuitable inventory, while a high price does not guarantee value.

Authorized-seller files, sellers.json and SupplyChain disclosures address particular transparency and spoofing problems. They do not prove human traffic, appropriate content or incrementality. MRC's invalid-traffic guidance also treats privacy requirements as constraints, not obstacles to engineer around. [38] [39] [58]

January 2026 MRC auction-transparency standards call for disclosures that help explain auction mechanics and prices; they remain voluntary standards, not proof that every platform follows them. Content-level verification likewise requires more context than a domain or isolated keyword. Do not confuse reporting on a difficult topic with endorsing it, or use crude exclusions that penalize protected groups. [59] [60]

For a family-friendly project, examine the whole path: creative, placement, destination, download and subsequent monetization. A G-rated ad can lead to an unsuitable page. A domain allowlist cannot guarantee every dynamic page or user upload is acceptable. These checks reduce specific risks; they are not complete safety certification.

Contextual relevance and actual data flows

Selecting a placement from the current topic or query can avoid some behavioral profiling, but the word contextual does not guarantee privacy. Requests can still transmit identifiers, IP addresses and URLs. Hashing is not automatic anonymization, and server-side collection does not remove obligations. Collect only needed information, limit retention and access, and make promises match actual behavior. [40] [41]

Research estimates of publisher tracking value differ substantially. A 2019 observational draft estimated roughly 4% revenue uplift from cookie availability. A 2024 empirical revision reported average impression-price decreases of 18% in desktop and 23% in-app settings without tracking, across different large datasets. These are different settings and estimands, not randomized universal effects or advertiser ROI. They justify neither declaring tracking worthless nor treating it as necessary. [42] [43]

Candidate Blackwish constraints are no user artwork or prompts sent to advertising platforms, no advertising identifiers embedded in creative exports, no sensitive-inference audiences, and no secret new telemetry. Coarse aggregates may be preferable when they actually answer a legitimate question. The current implementation is not certified by these proposed constraints; a real data-flow inventory would be required before any integration.

Claims children and legal boundaries

This is general issue-spotting checked on 23 October 2026, not legal advice, legal clearance, or a complete global survey. Actual obligations depend on audience, jurisdiction, commercial status, claims and data flows. Binding laws and rules, regulator guidance, case-specific enforcement and voluntary standards are distinct.

Claims and commercial relationships

FTC substantiation policy requires an adequate evidentiary basis for objective express and implied claims before dissemination. A disclaimer cannot substitute for support for the headline promise. For Blackwish, avoid unsupported claims of guaranteed creativity, reading improvement, universal suitability, exclusivity, copyright clearance or performance on untested platforms. [44]

Endorsements should be honest and unexpected material connections disclosed clearly in the relevant medium. Payment, gifts, employment and affiliate commissions may matter. Native-advertising guidance separately warns that format can mislead about independence even when product claims are true. A paid tutorial or recommendation should not masquerade as independent instruction or earned praise. [45] [46]

The FTC's reviews rule addresses fabricated testimonials, certain sentiment-conditioned incentives, deceptive insider endorsements and other specified practices. A synthetic avatar must not be passed off as a real satisfied customer. The Copyright Office's January 2025 report also distinguishes human creative authorship from machine-determined expression; AI assistance and prompting do not justify blanket ownership assurances. Copyrightability, licensing, infringement and likeness rights remain separate questions. [47] [48]

Washington's Consumer Protection Act independently prohibits unfair or deceptive trade practices. The existence of federal guidance is not a complete jurisdictional analysis. [52]

Children and family friendly presentation

COPPA scope depends on covered child-directed services or actual knowledge of collection from children under 13, among other conditions. A family-friendly theme alone does not decide scope, and a terms-of-service age statement is not a complete escape. Persistent identifiers and third-party collection can matter even without a signup form. [50]

The amended rule published 22 April 2025 generally required compliance by 22 April 2026, with some Safe Harbor provisions earlier. Covered non-integral disclosures, including targeted-advertising disclosures, require separate verifiable parental consent, alongside strengthened security and retention requirements. Scope and exceptions still matter; this is not a claim that every contextual ad is forbidden. [49]

FTC staff recommends avoiding blurred advertising to children rather than assuming adult-style disclosures solve the problem. A prudent Blackwish candidate is separation of creative play and teaching from promotion, no behavioral profiling of children, no vulnerability targeting, and no rewards or monetization gates that pressure children into ads. Teen audiences also deserve protection. Here G-rated describes intended family-friendly content, not an official rating or proof of legal compliance. [51]

Sensitive information and accessible choice

Washington's My Health My Data Act can cover health inferences from nonhealth information and is not limited to HIPAA-covered entities. Do not repurpose creative content or usage to infer mental or physical health for advertising. Ordinary creative activity is not automatically health data; applicability requires the actual facts and statutory definitions. [53]

WCAG 2.2 AA is a candidate design target, not a conformance claim. DOJ guidance explains accessibility duties for covered public accommodations, but WCAG 2.2 AA is not one uniform statutory mandate for every private site. Assess real captions, focus, keyboard controls, contrast, targets and disclosures rather than relying on a label. [54] [55]

Avoid disguised ads, false urgency, misleading download buttons, confirm-shaming, hidden terms and obstructed exits. If email promotion is considered later, CAN-SPAM guidance includes truthful routing and subjects, relevant identification, a postal address and usable opt-out, with requests honored within ten business days. Permission-based subscription and immediate easy unsubscribe are candidate practices; this is not a claim that the law universally requires double opt-in. [56] [57]

A practical candidate strategy for Blackwish

Begin with the current evidence boundary

The supplied project context describes a free, offline-first, G-rated creative generator and educational project. The internal delivery baseline is **PREVIEW v7.1**, not an independently audited public launch. A separate phonetic-print prototype is tiny exploratory ARPABET work, not established reading instruction and not integrated into the main builder. Desktop synthetic checks do not establish Android operation, universal accessibility or real-audience efficacy.

This context supports a conservative claim hierarchy: demonstrated behavior in a named build and tested environment; clearly marked exploratory features; longer-term aspirations stated as aspirations. Advertising must not collapse those layers. A demonstration recommendation is not authorization to release the build.

Candidate content ladder

1. **A short honest orientation.** Identify Blackwish and the actual purpose in ordinary language. Show one supported outcome and name the tested version and platform. Do not imply a finished show, mobile application or integrated teaching system unless that is what exists and has been verified.
2. **An optional complete walkthrough.** Explain what the human chooses, what the tool supplies, and how to keep desired details, inspect optional sources and export where supported. Disclose selection, edits, setup and limitations.
3. **A useful standalone sample.** Offer a candidate worksheet, example or explanation that remains useful without installation, signup or purchase. A short complete fictional scene can convey tone without withholding all value behind a funnel.

4. **A precise reference.** Keep cost, license, platform, offline behavior, setup needs and supported capabilities distinguishable. Free access must not be silently redefined as a later purchase or data bargain.
5. **Separate optional future offers.** Only describe a paid complement, sponsorship, donation or service if it is actually chosen and exists, with truthful terms. Do not assign speculative revenue to current free use.

These are private planning candidates, not drafted public promises. The order is intended to reduce mismatch before distribution expense, not to claim an optimal funnel or universal attention span.

A candidate outcome ledger

Record separately: relevant reach where credibly known; correct understanding; a successfully completed voluntarily chosen task; explicitly reported not-for-me decisions; attention and time burden; privacy burden; complaints and mismatch; support and serving costs; and incremental contribution or declared mission spending. Do not collect new information merely because a ledger names it.

A reason not to adopt the tool should be as easy to find as a reason to try it. A full exit without purchase is permitted. Retention is optional when the need is one-time. There should be no hidden advertising inside phonetic play, no compulsory mantras, and no use of Holy Fear to evoke insecurity or imply threats. The communication should support agency, not manufacture dependence.

What would have to be known before an action proposal

The unresolved inputs are actual feature and platform evidence; intended audience and locations; rights and license terms; data flows and vendors; credible useful-outcome definitions; cost and support capacity; real funding; and the user's chosen authorization boundary. The research does not establish demand, a best channel, optimum repetition, educational transfer, willingness to pay, legal coverage or sustainable Blackwish revenue.

Three distinct text reviews

The following is an operational interpretation of POINT, BRIDGE, PATH and SHADOW for this research, not a verbatim statement of Blackwish canon. The passes review text and proposed reasoning only. Passing them does not establish empirical efficacy, legal compliance, safety certification, ratification or permission to deploy.

Review one evidence and the meaning of benefit

POINT is useful discovery rather than universal persuasion. A material claim should name a beneficiary, an outcome and the relevant alternative. The candidate statement that a demonstration helps people judge fit is a design hypothesis; it must not become a claim that Blackwish improves everyone's creativity.

BRIDGE is the primary source and design-specific outcome. Retail purchase lift, laboratory recall, an industry standard and a Blackwish build check are different evidence classes. The bridge fails when a study's intermediate outcome is silently relabeled as welfare or when a historical average becomes a local forecast.

PATH is an inspectable claim-to-source register with version, population, outcome, horizon and uncertainty. Keep demonstrated capability separate from aspiration. For a hypothetical economic example, preserve the invented inputs rather than turning arithmetic into empirical support.

SHADOW includes selection bias, small or noisy effects, publication and transport limits, null-result misreading, unmeasured harms, and repeated winners selected from many variants. The repair is bounded language and an explicit unknown, not a ceremonial assurance that more reviews have eliminated uncertainty.

Review two agency and the audience experience

POINT is informed voluntary choice, including the choice to decline. The intended result is not that nobody can resist the message. An enjoyable sample can be complete in itself; a one-time successful task can be enough.

BRIDGE is truthful substantiation, clear commercial origin and relevant permission. Fiction, testimonials, sponsorship and teaching should be distinguishable. A G-rated surface cannot carry the entire burden of child protection, privacy or accessibility.

PATH is a usable demonstration, nearby qualifications, transparent terms, accessible alternatives and an easy exit. The same practical facts should survive in the text version. Do not make disclosure depend on interpreting lore, noticing a fleeting label, or understanding an adult commercial convention.

SHADOW includes hidden instruction, fear exploitation, compulsory repetition, deceptive scarcity, disguised endorsement and children mistaking promotion for teaching. The repair is to remove the exploitative mechanism and preserve useful information, not merely add a disclaimer to a contradictory experience.

Review three execution and sustainable distribution

POINT is sustainable distribution without outrunning readiness. Additional audience attention is not beneficial if the promised task cannot be completed or support capacity collapses. Promotion should not become a substitute for product work.

BRIDGE is versioned build evidence, rights, explicit cost assumptions and actual authorization. A checked desktop preview is not verified mobile operation. A download is not revenue. A research recommendation is not manual ratification.

PATH is reversible private drafting, preserved originals, a bounded future decision specification, and a clear checkpoint before any publication, spending, tracking or audience evaluation. Keep candidate constraints distinct from implemented behavior and claims of compliance.

SHADOW includes attribution mistaken for profit, fictional lifetime values, scaling beyond cash or support capacity, hidden vendor data flows, and internal QA described as a public audit. The

repair is scope correction and a factual dependency list. If a necessary input is unknown, do not manufacture it to complete a persuasive narrative.

Bounded Death Knell and counterexamples

Here Death Knell means adversarial text review of each material proposal: seek a plausible counterexample, retain the conditions under which the proposal survives, and reject unsupported universal claims. It is not empirical testing or certification. Stop repetitive review when it produces no new material distinction; reopen when claims, audience, product, law or distribution materially change.

Claim under pressure	Counterexample	Bounded conclusion
More attention means more benefit	Repetition irritates the audience or makes a false slogan familiar	Attention is diagnostic; usefulness, accuracy and burden require separate evaluation
High conversion proves good advertising	Existing users would have arrived without it	Separate attribution from incremental outcomes
A memorable creative persuades effectively	People recall the joke but misunderstand the tool	Assess comprehension and task fit, not recall alone
Useful content will spread organically	A valuable tutorial reaches few people	Usefulness and discovery are separate; no virality promise
Free means no cost to the audience	Setup, time, data and confusion are burdens	Explain nonmonetary costs and permit refusal
Contextual means anonymous	The placement still sends identifiers and page URLs	Inspect actual data flows, not marketing labels
More subscriptions show audience benefit	Users pay to escape a worsened free experience	Keep funding outcomes and audience experience separate
Retention is always success	A person finishes one satisfying character and leaves	Judge success against the person's task and recurrence need
A profitable pilot can scale indefinitely	Auction costs and support load rise	Examine marginal economics, cash and capacity
G-rated means safe for every child	Hidden promotion, unsuitable links or tracking remain	Separate content intent from age, privacy and destination review
Three text reviews prove readiness	The reviewed build still fails on an untested device	Text consistency does not replace relevant product evidence
Better measurement justifies collecting more	The extra data creates burden without changing a decision	Minimize collection and require separate authorization

These counterexamples narrow the strategy rather than defeat advertising as a whole. A truthful, useful message in an appropriate context can still be valuable. The research does not require pessimism; it requires not claiming more than the evidence and the actual offering support.

Decision checklist and teaching reference

Before any future action is proposed

- Define the beneficiary and one concrete useful outcome. Allow a successful one-off use and an informed refusal.
- Identify whether the purpose is mission distribution, financial acquisition or publisher funding.
- Verify the named build, platform, features, setup, offline behavior, price and license claims.
- Separate actual product capture, edited demonstrations, illustrations, fiction and aspiration.
- Provide an accessible complete explanation and a sample that is useful without purchase.
- Name the relevant counterfactual, time horizon and uncertainty; do not substitute dashboard attribution.
- Include full incremental costs, cash timing, support capacity and the best nonadvertising alternative.
- Inspect actual data flows, sensitive inferences, children, vendors, retention and destinations.
- Disclose sponsorship and preserve independent criticism; never invent customers or testimonials.
- Distinguish standards, legal requirements, research findings and candidate safeguards.
- Preserve original materials and record unresolved inputs rather than silently filling gaps.
- Obtain explicit manual ratification for publication, spending, tracking, recruitment, testing or deployment.

Terms worth keeping distinct

Term	Meaning in this dossier
Attribution	A rule assigning observed outcomes to contacts; not necessarily causal
Incrementality	Difference caused by a policy relative to a specified alternative
Absolute lift	Difference in outcome rates, often expressed in percentage points
Relative lift	Absolute difference divided by the baseline rate
Elasticity	Percentage outcome change associated with a 1% input change; not ROAS
iROAS	Incremental revenue divided by incremental ad spend; not profit
Contribution	Receipts less specified variable costs, before or after acquisition as explicitly stated

Term	Meaning in this dossier
eCPM	Realized revenue or cost per thousand specified impressions; denominator matters
Marginal return	Return on the next increment, not the average of previous spending
Holdout	A comparison group under a defined alternative policy
Intention to treat	Analysis by assigned policy, not only people delivered an ad or clicking
Welfare	Audience and wider benefits and costs, not reducible here to sales or engagement

Bottom line: The most promising Blackwish candidate is useful demonstration plus transparent explanation, distributed only where it adds worthwhile discovery. Preserve agency, keep the free offering honest, and make the creator's full economics visible. The research supports this as a disciplined direction for private planning; it does not certify an execution, establish a budget or authorize a campaign.

Source bibliography

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